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FNCE 646: Sustainable Finance

Individual Project: TC Energy's Indigenous Partnership Strategy

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Introduction

Environmental, Social, and Government (ESG) initiatives have increasingly become integrated into corporate strategy as organizations seek to manage risks, maintain stakeholder relationships, and create long-term shareholder value. While many ESG initiatives are criticized as being driven primary by reputational concerns, some initiatives can be directly linked to financial performance and shareholder value creation. One excellent example is TC Energy and their continued equity and valued partnership with Indigenous communities throughout North America.

This report examines TC Energy's Indigenous partnership strategy as a financially material sustainability initiative. It argues that Indigenous partnerships are not merely social responsibility programs designed to check a box, rather they are strategic business initiatives that reduce regulatory risk, improve project approval outcomes, strengthen stakeholder relationships, and create long-term shareholder value (see Figure A2 in Appendix) (Yahoo! Finance, 2026). This report evaluates the strategic rationale for these partnerships, their financial impact, and their environmental and social materiality.

Company Overview

TC Energy is headquartered in Calgary, Alberta and is one of North America's largest energy infrastructure companies, operating natural gas pipelines, liquids pipelines, and power generation assets across Canada, the United States, and Mexico (see Figure A1 in Appendix) (TC Energy, 2026). As a developer and operator of large-scale infrastructure projects, the company faces significant regulatory, environmental, and social challenges. Among the most important of these challenges is the requirement to engage Indigenous communities whose traditional territories may be affected by pipeline development and operation. For more than 40 years, TC Energy has been engaging with Indigenous groups. They recognize Indigenous groups as rightsholders who have a distinct relationship to their land. They understand that TC Energy's business activities have the potential to affect Indigenous groups in tangible ways, and that is why they go to great lengths to create real partnerships that are beneficial to all stakeholders involved (TC Energy, 2025).

Sustainability

In October of 2024, TC Energy officially spun off all of its oil assets into a new corporation called South Bow. This change allowed TC Energy to focus on managing its natural gas assets in addition to its growing portfolio of low-carbon energy projects within the Power and Energy Solutions division.

François Poirier, TC Energy's President and Chief Executive Officer noted that following the transaction, TC Energy will focus on natural gas infrastructure, supported by strong, long-term fundamentals and power and energy solutions, driven by nuclear, pumped hydro energy storage and new energy opportunities while continuing its history of maximizing asset value and operational performance (TC Energy, 2023).

Since the transaction that created a new TC Energy portfolio of assets that are more sustainably focused, they have achieved a 12 per cent reduction in methane emissions from their 2019 baseline. They have invested $8.7M in environmentally-focused community initiatives to advance biodiversity and climate resilience and they have planted over 155,000 seedlings across 50 hectares to restore caribou habitats (TC Energy, 2025). They are focused on a pragmatic and financially disciplined strategy that focuses on progressing emissions reduction efforts across their assets and investing in lowcarbon technologies—effectively balancing energy security, affordability and sustainability (TC Energy, 2025).

They have introduced a methane-intensity target, underlining their commitment to operational Green House Gases (GHG) emissions reductions. With a 40 to 55 per cent reduction by 2035 in their methane intensity from their 2019 baseline, they have advanced the application of operational best practices and made targeted investments to enhance performance across their footprint (TC Energy, 2025).

Additionally, they have provided over $5M to Indigenous community-led initiatives to reinforce economic growth under their sustainable umbrella (TC Energy, 2025). This sustainability angle works in concert with the Indigenous groups environmental vision for responsible energy development. These practices of listening to the Indigenous groups for their insight into where to best build projects due to environmental risks goes back to the 1980's. Art Cunningham was one of the first Indigenous leaders to partner with TC Energy (formerly NOVA followed by a merger with TransCanada) with respect to responsible energy infrastructure development. He stated "When I started going into communities, people would point out things on the land—like where a creek actually flows or how it changes seasonally. I would take that knowledge back to our engineers during planning. The information helped narrow down where to cross or how to route the pipeline. We were learning that traditional knowledge could meaningfully support and improve our technical work (TC Energy, 2026)."

TC Energy has been instrumental in it environmental practices and they work diligently to ensure that any part of the land that is disturbed during the construction phase is then returned to its original pristine state. TC Energy project planning and development includes environmental considerations. As

part of the West Path Program's Environmental Protection Plans, data is collected on environmental elements such as soils and terrain, wildlife and wildlife habitat, vegetation and wetlands, fish and fish habitat, water and water quality, heritage resources, air emissions and acoustic environment. That data helps to identify environmental protection measures to be implemented with the goal of environmentally responsible construction and returning disturbed areas to equivalent land capability (TC Energy, 2025).

TC Energy's integrated approach to environmental stewardship across North America demonstrates a strategic commitment to ecosystem restoration that mitigates operational risks while creating measurable social and environmental value. Within Canada, through their multi-year partnership with the Alternative Land Use Services (ALUS) New Acre Project, the company is leveraging collaborative land management frameworks to rehabilitate 135 acres of marginal farmland across Ontario and Quebec, simultaneously addressing biodiversity loss and watershed resilience in regions critical to pipeline infrastructure operations (ALUS, 2023).

In the US, this initiative is complemented by the company's contribution to Luisiana's Woodlands Preserve, which illustrates the interconnection between ecological health and community resilience; by restoring forested wetlands capable of absorbing 32 million gallons of water annually. Since 2004, TC Energy has been reducing flood risk exposure in adjacent communities while creating habitat for over 160 native and migratory bird species, thereby addressing both adaptation and stakeholder engagement objectives (TC Energy, 2025).

At its southern boundary of its operational footprint within Mexico, the company's partnership with Oceanus A.C. to restore coral reef ecosystems in Veracruz further demonstrates geographic diversity in environmental stewardship by transporting 1,500 coral colonies on the Isla Lobos Reef (OCEANUS A.C., 2026), (TC Energy, 2025) . TC Energy is contributing to marine ecosystem recovery while positioning itself as a responsible corporate partner in a region increasingly vulnerable to climate-related ocean stress. Collectively, these environmental initiatives reflect a strategic recognition that long-term operational sustainability and license to operate are contingent upon proactive investment in ecosystem restoration, stakeholder relationships, and climate adaptation across multiple jurisdictions where TC Energy conducts business.

Strategic Indigenous Partnerships

For more than 40 years, TC Energy has been engaging with Indigenous groups. They recognize Indigenous groups as rightsholders who have a distinct relationship to the land. They understand that their business activities have the potential to affect those groups in tangible ways (TC Energy, 2025).

The primary strategic rationale for Indigenous partnerships is the reduction of project risk. Large energy infrastructure projects face increasingly complex regulatory and social environments. Indigenous consultation requirements have expanded significantly as Canadian courts have reinforced the Crown's duty to consult and accommodate Indigenous peoples. While the legal duty to consult and accommodate Indigenous communities ultimately rests with the Crown, TC Energy plays a critical role in supporting this process through proactive engagement and relationship-building with affected Indigenous groups.

In developing major energy infrastructure projects, TC Energy works collaboratively with Indigenous communities to identify and address potential impacts on Aboriginal and treaty rights through a range of accommodation measures. These measures may include project design modifications, route adjustments, construction scheduling changes to minimize disruptions to traditional land use, environmental monitoring programs, habitat restoration initiatives, co-management arrangements, economic participation opportunities, and ongoing consultation throughout the project lifecycle. The effectiveness of these efforts depends on meaningful dialogue and a willingness by all parties to engage in flexible and constructive discussions that balance project objectives with Indigenous rights, interests, and long-term community benefits (Government of Canada, 2025).

Failure to establish strong relationships with Indigenous communities can result in project delays, legal challenges, increased costs, and reputational damage. These outcomes can materially affect shareholder value and stakeholder trust. Indigenous partnerships help address these risks by creating alignment between project developers and local communities. When communities participate in projects, they become long-term stakeholders rather that external observers. This participation process creates a bond between the partners which results in a win-win scenario.

Additionally, Indigenous partnerships support TC Energy's broader corporate strategy of developing and operating long-lived infrastructure assets. By improving project certainty and reducing stakeholder conflict, these initiatives enhance the company's ability to generate predictable cash flows which is beneficial for all shareholders (TC Energy, 2025).

Their strategy also supports the concept of a social license to operate. While regulatory approval is necessary, public and community support increasingly influences project success. Indigenous partnerships strengthen this social license by demonstrating a commitment to reconciliation and shared prosperity. TC Energy has been working with Indigenous groups for over 40 years, and their long-term communication and partnerships are what provide their operations with the competitive advantage that is required to succeed in today's challenging energy development and operating environment.

Financial Materiality Analysis

One of the strongest arguments supporting TC Energy's Indigenous partnership strategy is its financial materiality. The economic impact of project approval timelines can be tremendous if those projects are delayed due to a lack of consultation and accommodation. The projects that TC Energy are involved with also provide for economic investment for communities throughout Canada. The urgency to build infrastructure and resource projects is not limited to nation-building projects. Canada must find ways to meet its increasing energy demand, to advance reconciliation with Indigenous Peoples, create economic opportunity, and grow new trade markets. In addition, nation-building projects will themselves require supporting infrastructure, creating additional project opportunities of varying complexity. Canada's current regulatory process is too complex, too subjective, and too long. It lacks both the speed and predictability required for investor confidence, delaying critical projects that would serve Canada's interests (TC Energy, 2025).

Project Risks

Infrastructure projects require extensive regulatory approvals. Delays can increase capital costs, postpone revenue generation, and reduce project net present value. Additionally, project risks can range in scope from protesters, environmental damage, challenging terrain, and a lack of quality subcontractors. TC Energy's Coastal GasLink pipeline (see Figure A4 in Appendix) demonstrates the cascading impact of inadequately managed project risks in large-scale energy infrastructure. The project illustrates how risk identification, mitigation, and contingency planning failures can compound across operational, financial, and stakeholder dimensions. Originally budgeted at $6.2 billion in 2018, the project more than doubled in price driven by labour shortages, contractor underperformance and disputes, and environmental challenges (RCI, 2023).

The delay in the project and the additional costs associated with it did not play well in the markets as their stock price and total market capitalization declined by significant numbers. The additional risk of

schedule extensions and the continued scope creep could add another $1.2 billion cost exposure in 2024 (RCI, 2023). Even with careful planning, risk mitigation, and budgeting from a company as well versed in pipeline development as TC Energy, many delays and costs can find their way into the project deliverables no matter the precision put forth from the start.

TC Energy's delayed Indigenous equity partnership for the Nova Gas Transmission Ltd. (NGTL) System (see Figure A3 in Appendix) and the Foothills Pipeline assets exemplifies how transaction structuring and financing risks can derail even strategically important stakeholder agreements. The $1 billion agreement, announced in July 2024, would enable 72 Indigenous communities to acquire a 5.34 percent stake in the NGTL and Foothills Pipeline assets which comprised of 25,000 kilometers of natural gas infrastructure (Pipelineonline.ca, 2024).

The deal was delayed due to an identified transaction structuring issue within the NGTL partnership, with Bloomberg reporting that the $1 billion bond deal to finance the agreement did not close as planned. This delay reveals critical risk management gaps: insufficient due diligence on partnership governance structures, inadequate financial contingency planning, and underestimation of complexity in multistakeholder transaction design. The partnership's failure to anticipate structuring impediments undermines TC Energy's broader stakeholder management objectives and jeopardizes the strategic intent of the deal; both the company's debt reduction goals and its relationship building with Indigenous communities (Pipelineonline.ca, 2024). Effective risk management in Indigenous or general partnership transactions requires rigorous upfront assessment of partnership agreement architecture, robust stress testing of financing assumptions, and contingency protocols to prevent operational or structural issues from cascading into reputational and financial loss.

Environmental and Social Materiality Assessment

Environmental considerations are closely connected to Indigenous engagement. Indigenous communities often possess extensive traditional knowledge regarding local ecosystems, wildlife, water systems, and land use patterns. TC Energy incorporates Indigenous intelligent perspectives into environmental planning and project design processes. This can improve environmental outcomes by identifying risks that might otherwise be overlooked (TC Energy, 2025). Environmental stewardship also affects project approvals and stakeholder trust. Effective environmental management therefore contributes both environmental and financial value.

The social impacts of Indigenous partnerships are substantial. These initiatives provide employment opportunities, business development opportunities, procurement contracts, training programs, and long-term wealth creation for all within the communities and beyond through ownership participation.

For many Indigenous communities, equity ownership represents a significant shift from historical consultation models of the 20th century toward meaningful economic participation of today. The partnerships contribute to reconciliation efforts by supporting Indigenous self-determination and economic development. This self-determination and economic development provides an excellent opportunity for Indigenous communities to prosper financially, mentally, and holistically.

IFRS and SASB

Under International Financial Reporting Standards (IFRS) Sustainability Disclosure Standards and Sustainability Accounting Standard Board (SASB) materiality frameworks, Indigenous relations are clearly financially material for infrastructure companies. Materiality exists when an issue can reasonably influence investor decisions or affect enterprise value. Because Indigenous partnerships influence regulatory approvals, project economics, stakeholder relationships, and operational stability, they meet this threshold. Similarly, environmental performance affects regulatory compliance, reputation, and long-term operational visibility. These factors demonstrate that TC Energy's Indigenous partnership strategy is material from both a financial and sustainable perspective.

The SASB framework identifies sustainability issues that impact a company's financial performance, shareholder value, and competitive position. Materiality is assessed from the investor perspective: which environmental, social, and governance (ESG) risks or opportunities affect earnings, growth, and shareholder returns? For TC Energy, SASB-material issues include regulatory risk, social license, reputation, and operational continuity. The framework is economically focused and emphasizes disclosure of financially relevant sustainability information (SASB, 2022).

IFRS S1 General Requirements and S2 Climate-related Disclosures introduce double materiality: both financial materiality and the impact of sustainability issues on the company. Value impacts materially the company's pressure on people, communities, and the environment. This stakeholder-inclusive approach requires companies to disclose how they affect Indigenous communities, workers, ecosystems, and other non-shareholder stakeholders—not only how these relationships affect shareholder returns. Under IFRS S1/S2, materiality is assessed bidirectionally: what affects the company, and what the company affects (IFRS, 2026).

Reputational Risks

TC Energy's announcement in July 2024 of a $1 billion equity interest purchase agreement enabling up to 72 Indigenous communities to acquire a 5.34 per cent stake in the NGTL System and Foothills Pipeline assets was positioned as "Canada's largest Indigenous equity ownership agreement," immediately elevating the company's reputational position as an industry leader in Indigenous economic partnership and reconciliation. The announcement's framing around "Indigenous ownership as the path to a more prosperous nation" and support from senior Alberta government officials created a high-visibility, flagship branding opportunity for TC Energy. The deal positioned the company as distinguishing itself from peers through substantive Indigenous economic participation rather than consultation-only models. However, this elevated visibility creates proportional reputational risk: any failure to execute or deliver promised partnership benefits becomes a highly visible demonstration of TC Energy's commitment gap between public reconciliation rhetoric and operational reality (NASDAQ OMX, 2024).

The partnership's subsequent financing delay—the failure of the $1 billion bond deal to close as planned—materially damages TC Energy's reputational position in several dimensions.

First, it signals execution risk on a signature commitment to Indigenous communities and government partners, undermining the credibility of the CEO's assertion that "Indigenous ownership is the path to a more prosperous nation." Second, the delay extends the period of uncertainty for the 72 communities, many of whom made internal decisions and communicated to members based on the July 2024 announcement, only to face indefinite postponement. Third, if the partnership ultimately fails to close, it will be perceived as a broken commitment to Indigenous partners, creating reputational damage not only to TC Energy but potentially creating organizational memory and skepticism within Indigenous communities about energy company partnership sincerity (EnergyNow Media, 2024).

The reputational trajectory is thus reversed: from industry-leading partnership innovator to a company unable to execute on a high-profile Indigenous commitment. This dynamic is particularly acute given TC Energy's history of major project delays (Coastal GasLink) and regulatory challenges (Trans Mountain), where Indigenous partnership challenges have been material risk factors—the Indigenous equity partnership was explicitly announced to address and differentiate from this history.

Strategic Evaluation

TC Energy's Indigenous equity partnership demonstrates a strategic calculus that generates shareholder value on multiple dimensions while partially addressing stakeholder expectations, though with material execution and benefit distribution risks. From a shareholder value perspective, the initiative delivers concrete benefits: the $1 billion capital infusion directly reduces leverage and improves the company's debt–to–EBITDA ratio; a critical key metric for regulated pipeline operators' cost of capital and investor returns (TC Energy, 2025). Beyond immediate debt reduction, the partnership strategically de-risks TC Energy's social license by converting Indigenous communities from potential project obstacles (as evidenced by Coastal GasLink cost overruns and Trans Mountain regulatory delays) into equity aligned stakeholders with direct financial interest in asset performance and operational continuity.

This risk mitigation has quantifiable value: reduced litigation, lower project costs, and higher cash flow visibility which are both material to shareholder returns. The initiative also aligns with TC Energy's post spinoff corporate strategy (following the October 2024 South Bow liquids separation) of positioning the company as a pure play regulated natural gas infrastructure operator in addition to their sustainable power and energy division which produces predicable, inflation and geopolitical protected cash flows. This is a position that increasingly requires demonstrated Indigenous partnership capability and social license strength to support both current asset value and future growth opportunities.

The partnership's delayed financing closure and the passive nature of Indigenous equity participation reveal the tension between financial engineering and stakeholder benefit. While the 5.34% stake generates capital for TC Energy and provides dividend distributions to Indigenous communities, it does not translate to governance influence or meaningful operational voice for communities, it does not create structural risk to stakeholder expectations and long–term relationship durability. Indigenous communities may perceive the partnership as primarily serving TC Energy's financial objectives (debt reduction, social license) while providing limited control over assets and decisions affecting their traditional territories, potentially undermining both the reconciliation objective and the social license value that justified the transaction from a shareholder perspective.

Recommendations

To maximize both shareholder value and stakeholder benefit from Indigenous partnership strategy, TC Energy should pursue a multi-pronged approach that deepens equity participation, strengthens governance structures, and integrates Indigenous partnerships into core corporate strategy.

First, TC Energy should expand Indigenous equity participation beyond the current passive 5.34% stake model by offering meaningful governance rights, board observation seats, consultation protocols on operational decisions affecting traditional territories, and structured participation in asset monetization and capital allocation decisions. This will convert passive financial ownership into active stakeholder partnership that strengthens social license durability and reduces long-term litigation and regulatory delay risk.

Second, the company should establish a formalized long-term partnership governance framework that clarifies benefit sharing mechanisms, dividend sustainability commitments, dispute resolution protocols, and succession planning across the 72-community structure, addressing the current ambiguity that created the $1 billion financing delay and therefore reducing future execution risk.

Third, TC Energy should implement rigorous impact measurement and disclosure aligned with both IFRS S1 and S2 double materiality standards and Indigenous community key successful metrics. The tracking of financial distributions in conjunction with measuring community-defined outcomes such as Indigenous employment stewardship, with public annual reporting to demonstrate reconciliation authenticity would add to the differentiation from performative competitor approaches.

Finally, TC Energy should integrate Indigenous partnership capability and community consultation into its future growth strategy, recognizing that regulated infrastructure expansion in Canada increasingly requires Indigenous relationship fortitude as a prerequisite to permitting and operations. Treating Indigenous partnerships not as risk mitigation add-ons, but as foundational to project development, therefore creating genuine economic interdependence between the company and the Indigenous communities.

Conclusion

TC Energy's $1 billion Indigenous equity partnership with 72 communities represents a significant but incomplete evolution in how major Canadian energy companies approach Indigenous relationships and accommodation obligations. The initiative demonstrates measurable shareholder value creation through debt reduction, social license de-risking, and strategic positioning in regulated energy infrastructure. TC Energy's experience offers both a cautionary example and a template for improvement. The path forward requires moving beyond equity participation as social license insurance toward genuine partnership models that integrate Indigenous communities as operational stakeholders with meaningful voice and decision-making authority over assets and operations affecting their traditional territories.

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Appendices

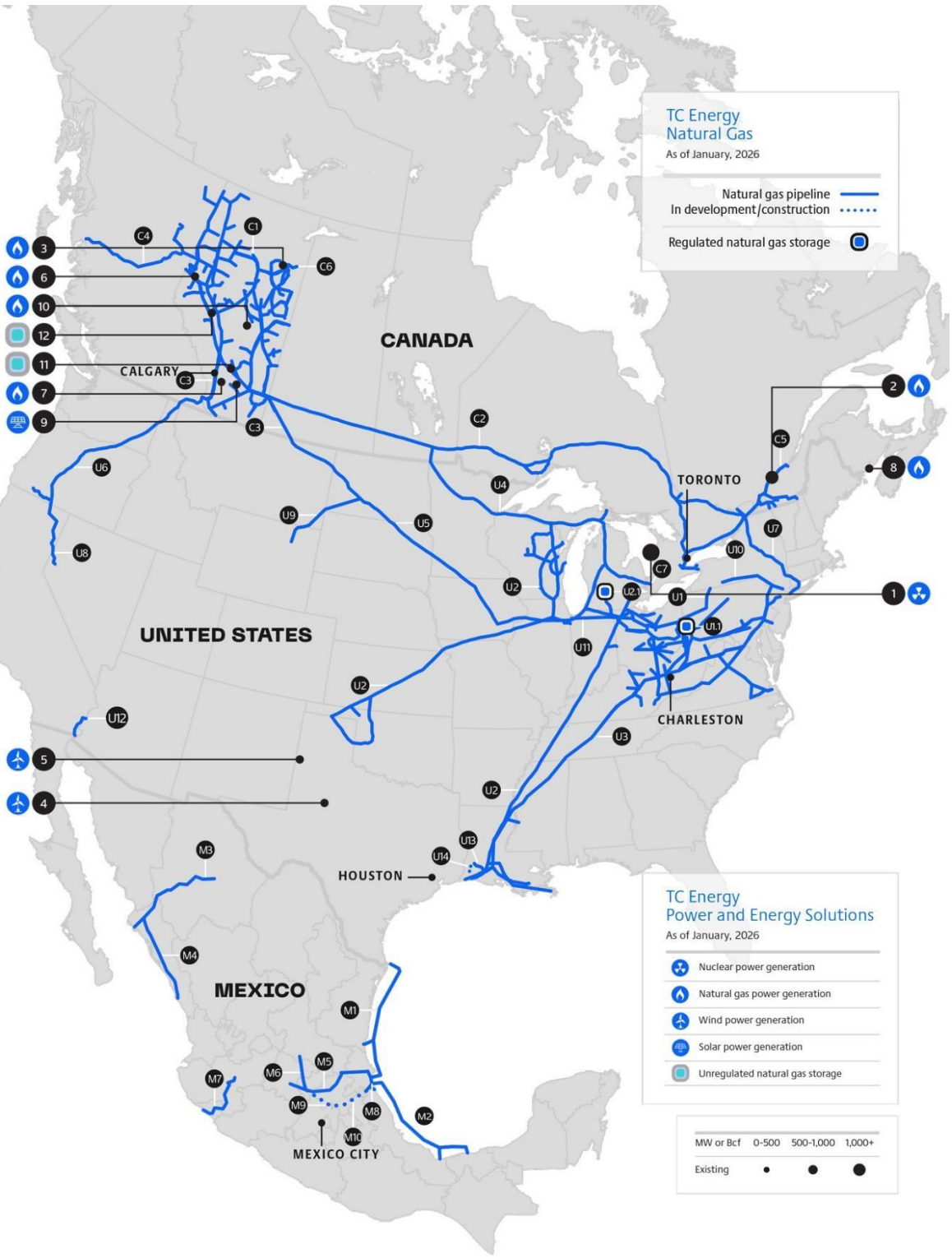


Figure A1 (TC Energy, 2026)



Figure A2 (Yahoo! Finance, 2026)



Figure A3 (TC Energy, 2024)

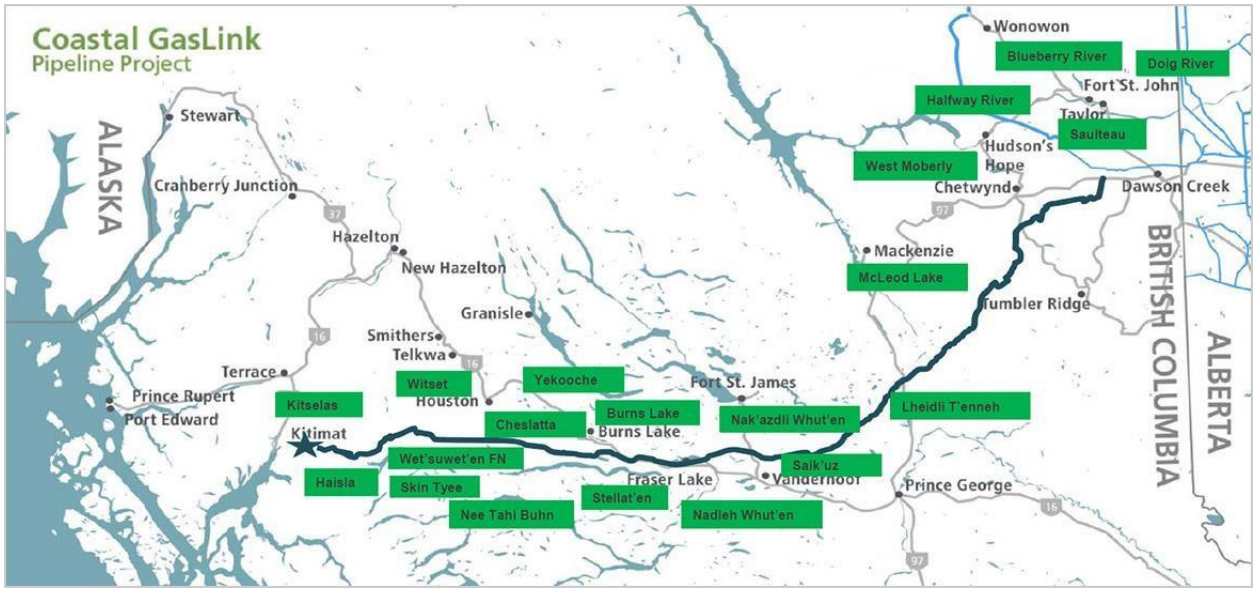


Figure A4 (TC Energy, 2018)